

Alibaba Group (BABA): Alibaba Cloud APSARA – Key Takeaways; Powering & Scaling for the Agentic era

We highlight key takeaways from the Alibaba Cloud APSARA Conference (“云栖大会”) held in Hangzhou, across Chairman and CEO keynote speeches that focused on powering and scaling towards Machine Intelligence/Artificial Super Intelligence (ASI) for the agentic AI era, an analyst meeting with Group Chairman and management, and sessions hosted by respective AI Cloud & Compute and AI Labs & Applications management/business heads. We are encouraged by Alibaba’s progress across its unique AI full-stack, namely **AI infrastructure** (targeting to reach 20GW in total data center power consumption by 2032, to be powered by Alibaba Cloud & partners, with its custom silicon T-head to contribute meaningfully to compute), **AI models** (with Qwen’s roadmap in sustaining amongst the top-tier, a multi-modal approach, Qwen4 family coming soon and Qwen4.5/5 to scale towards next 5-10T parameter sizes) and **AI applications/ecosystems** (focusing on Harness x Context x Model for the agentic era, with new QwenWork functionalities and ‘Enterprise Context’, connecting AI workforce agents with DingTalk for productivity and expanded capabilities).

With these, we maintain our above-street (vs. Visible Alpha Consensus Data) Alibaba Cloud revenue growth expectations of 53%/55%/55% year-on-year for Sep-2026/Dec-2026/Mar-2027 quarters. We anticipate investor focus around capex/funding sources in powering the 20GW power consumption target by 2032, which we estimate will be manageable, from a combination of asset heavy and asset light formats, 1) capex, funded by stable eCommerce EBITA, growing cloud profits, cash on balance sheet and future funding, 2) partnerships with data centers/telcos/others and 3) rental, esp. for overseas AI compute.

Reconciling power consumption/capex/cloud growth: We estimate 20GW by calendar year 2032 will imply 1-2GW increase p.a. over the next few years, from c.5-6GW in end-2025 (GSe), translating to Rmb200-300bn annual capex for Alibaba over the next few years, assuming c.US\$20-25bn capex per GW attributable to Alibaba from a T-head custom silicon dominated approach and mixture of asset heavy, asset light and rental (opex) compute. We believe its custom silicon T-head creates unique US\$/GW advantages vs. domestic and overseas peers, where T-Head could contribute to half of Alibaba Cloud compute medium-term, from c.10% today. Meanwhile, the company continues to expect US\$100bn external AI cloud revenue for calendar year 2030 and medium-term 20% EBITA margin, depending on the evolving capex-to-revenue conversion in the medium-term and internal/external revenue mix. We are currently forecasting Rmb209/243/260bn capex for

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FY27E/28E/29E.

- **20GW by 2032:** AI cloud as the supergrid for Machine Intelligence, where Alibaba expects Alibaba Cloud to reach 20GW in power consumption by 2032 to be powered by Alibaba Cloud & partners. The company expects continued strong compute demand from intelligent driving, embodied AI and world models. Fastest drivers of AI Cloud growth have been from frontier AI lab customers, physical AI and overseas markets, see [Exhibit 2](#).
- **Qwen's roadmap:** A clear path to Artificial Super Intelligence (ASI), with Qwen4 coming soon and Qwen4.5/5 to scale towards 5-10T parameter model sizes, alongside multi-modal understanding/generation. 1) Delving deep into real-world production scenarios, progressing towards recursive self-improvement (RSI); 2) Innovating model architecture to push efficiency; 3) Advancing toward full modality to expand the boundaries of agents; 4) Continuing to scale to push intelligence level.
- **Compute build-out/T-head:** Providing boundless power for machine intelligence, with Zhengwu V900 announced, at 3X performance of the current M890. Supernode architecture, scale-up and scale-out in forming one of the largest PPU clusters (to 500K cluster, eventually scaling towards 1M cluster). See [Exhibit 5](#) and [Exhibit 6](#).
- **MaaS ARR:** Qwen AI MaaS platform (Bailian) has reached Rmb20bn by end-Aug, vs. Rmb16bn/8bn in mid-Aug/mid-May 2026 ([Exhibit 3](#)), remains on track to reach Rmb30bn target by year-end 2026, where Qwen models continue to be the largest contributor.
- **AI agents/QwenWork:** Focusing on Harness x Context x Model, where private domain/enterprise data is becoming increasingly important for agentic performance. QwenWork introduced 'Enterprise Context' to improve QwenWork's productivity, and connection with DingTalk for step-improvement in productivity, while focusing on data security/access and control within each enterprise.
- **Overseas:** Alibaba Cloud now covers 31 countries/regions, with 106 availability zones and 3,200+ edge nodes ([Exhibit 4](#)), with IDCs to be launched over the next 12 months across Malaysia, Turkey, Germany, UAE, France, Netherlands, Finland, HK and Thailand, with typical 100 days in building a new data center, with increased 5-10X density per rack vs. previous and being run greener at <1.15 PUE. Private AI cloud growth has been accelerating amongst domestic and overseas enterprises.

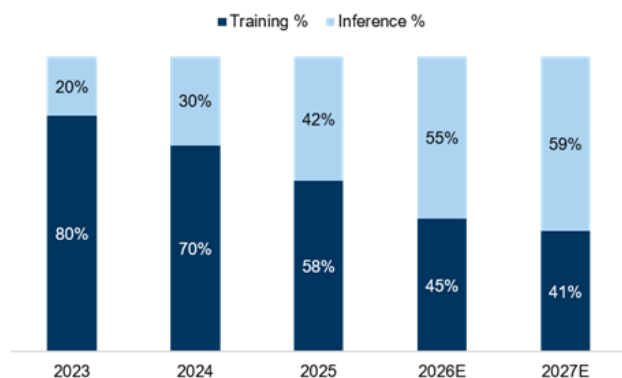
We continue to expect Alibaba to deliver a solid EPS recovery of +58%/+27% yoy for FY27E/FY28E (with strong inflection from Sep quarter), to be driven by continued leadership in its full-stack AI + Cloud business in China with further acceleration in cloud growth and a recovery in overall eCommerce profits with narrowing quick commerce losses. We are **Buy rated on BABA/9988.HK** with SOTP-based 12-month target prices of **US\$177/HK\$172**.

Key risks: (1) Lower-than-expected GMV growth due to macro/competition; (2) Slower-than-expected monetization in China retail; (3) Weaker-than-expected execution in key strategic investments; and (4) Cloud revenue growth deceleration.

See also our earlier reports on [Navigating China Internet & AI models: What to do from here; key themes & refreshed ideas into year-end](#).

Exhibit 1: Global AI compute spend: inference as % expected to exceed training in 26E

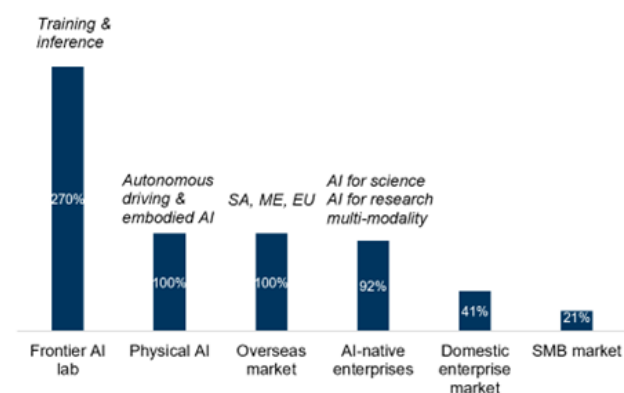
Gartner 2026 IaaS spend



Source: Gartner, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 2: Resilient cloud revenue growth from 6 business segments

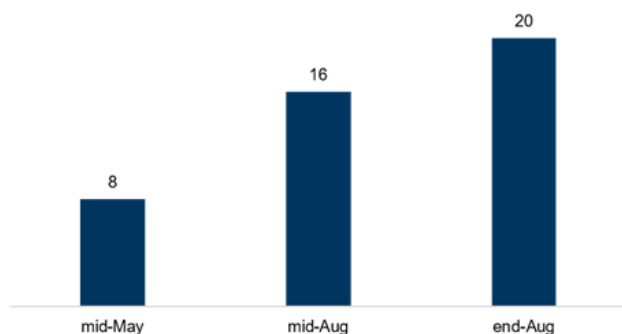
yoy growth



Source: Company data, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 3: MaaS: Accelerating ARR growth towards end-26 target of Rmb30bn

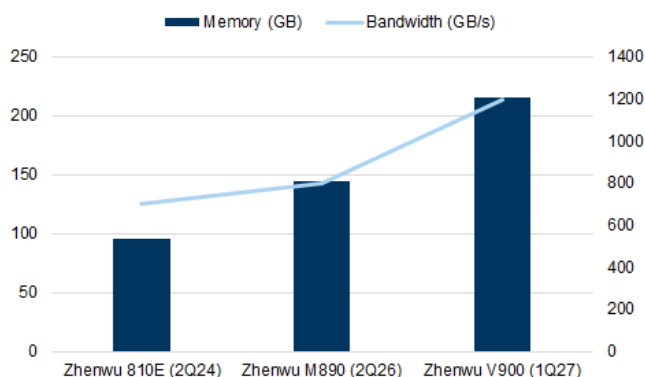
MaaS ARR (Rmb bn)



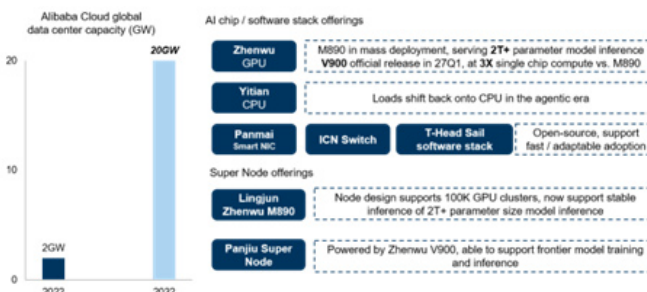
Source: Company data, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 4: Alibaba Cloud International: evolving cloud with leading technology and global dedicated services


Source: Company data

Exhibit 5: Zhenwu: high-performance AI infrastructure


Source: Company data, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 6: Data center capacity to reach 20GW by 2032E, partially contributed by in-house AI chip / software / Super Node offerings


Source: Company data, Data compiled by Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Key takeaways from APSARA Conference Day 1

Opening speeches from Alibaba Group Chairman Mr. Joe Tsai and CEO Mr. Eddie Wu

- The total amount of thinking supplied by machines in the future will be more than 1,000X the total amount of human thinking. Currently machine thinking is less than 3% of human thinking.
- **AI models:** Qwen will train 5-10T parameter models and push toward recursive self-improvement (RSI), while also strengthening multi-modal capabilities.
- **AI cloud:** By 2032, Alibaba Cloud aims to expand its global data center capacity to 20GW (10X increase vs. 2022).
- **AI chips:** The self-developed M890 supernode has successfully supported inference for 2T large models, and M890-based supernodes have already been scaled onto Alibaba Cloud this quarter. The company also released the next-generation AI chip Zhenwu V900 (3X performance vs. M890). T-Head's shipments are expected to increase substantially in the coming years.

Qwen: Towards Real-World Agent session

Liu Dayiheng, Alibaba Token Hub - Qwen LLM Project Lead, Token Foundry

- Qwen's goal is to 1) pursue higher intelligence and accelerate self-evolution through Qwen-Max series and 2) pursue the extreme cost-effectiveness through Qwen-Flash/Qwen-Plus/Qwen-27B.
- Qwen's roadmap for the agentic era is to 1) dive into real-world production and accelerate the evolution of RSI, 2) revamp model structures and push the boundaries of efficiency, 3) expand the boundaries of agents through multimodality, and 4) continue scaling.
- Qwen3.8 Max's user revenue grew 8.5X and token consumption surged 12X within 2 months compared with the previous generation.
- Compared with Qwen3.7 Flash, Qwen3.8 Flash's activated parameters are reduced to 1/3 and its training cost is cut to 1/9. On the inference side, the price per million input tokens drops to 1/4, prefilling throughput for ultra-long context improves 8.6X, and its AA score rises by 14 points.

Exhibit 7: Alibaba by segment performance and our estimates

By segment (Rmb mn)	FY27E	FY28E	FY29E	2Q25	2Q26E	3Q26E	4Q26E	1Q27E
				1QFY26	1QFY27	2QFY27E	3QFY27E	4QFY27E
Group revenue	1,119,967	1,240,292	1,380,447	247,652	268,953	270,894	310,807	269,313
yoy %	9%	11%	11%	2%	9%	9%	9%	11%
Group EBITA	124,389	160,024	197,282	38,844	27,329	27,483	40,237	29,341
EBITA margin %	11%	13%	14%	16%	10%	10%	13%	11%
yoy %	63%	29%	23%	-14%	-30%	203%	72%	475%
Adj. net profit attributable to shareholders	106,215	138,654	185,043	35,291	20,583	24,993	35,411	25,111
Adj. net margin %	9%	11%	13%	14%	8%	9%	11%	9%
yoy %	65%	31%	33%	-12%	-42%	139%	107%	1567%
Non-gaap EPS (Rmb)	43.17	54.71	72.65	14.75	8.52	10.38	14.18	9.96
yoy %	58%	27%	33%	-10%	-42%	138%	100%	1497%
By Business group								
E-commerce group								
Domestic GMV (GSe)	8,434	8,586	8,672	2,208	2,217	1,981	2,433	1,802
yoy %	1%	2%	1%	5%	0%	2%	2%	2%
E-commerce business group revenue	845,279	877,468	909,940	198,812	205,862	203,935	238,428	197,053
yoy %	1%	4%	4%		4%	0%	1%	1%
Customer management revenue (CMR)	325,284	332,067	340,105	89,199	82,547	75,203	97,100	70,434
yoy %	-5%	2%	2%	10%	-7%	-5%	-5%	-4%
E-commerce business group EBITA	162,748	177,248	194,727	39,988	39,749	37,116	48,639	37,243
EBITA margin %	19.3%	20.2%	21.4%	20.1%	19.3%	18.2%	20.4%	18.9%
yoy %	45%	9%	10%		-1%	239%	35%	49%
E-commerce EBITA excl. Quick Commerce	195,734	194,021	193,604	50,923	50,131	46,776	56,359	42,468
yoy %	-1%	-1%	0%		-2%	-1%	-1%	-1%
Quick Commerce EBITA (losses)	(32,987)	(16,772)	1,123	(10,935)	(10,382)	(9,660)	(7,720)	(5,225)
AI Cloud and compute services								
Revenue	241,299	332,277	441,657	33,418	48,437	60,967	67,130	64,764
yoy %	53%	38%	33%		45%	53%	55%	55%
External revenue yoy%	53%	42%	39%	26%	45%	53%	55%	57%
EBITA	30,534	46,519	66,248	2,419	5,628	7,438	8,660	8,808
EBITA margin %	12.7%	14.0%	15.0%	7.2%	11.6%	12.2%	12.9%	13.6%
AI labs and applications								
Revenue	14,801	19,241	26,168	2,882	3,338	3,579	3,815	4,069
yoy %	24%	30%	36%		16%	22%	26%	30%
EBITA	(50,959)	(49,065)	(49,720)	(3,224)	(13,861)	(12,276)	(12,207)	(12,614)
EBITA margin %	-344%	-255%	-190%	-112%	-415%	-343%	-320%	-310%
All others								
Revenue	91,544	92,460	93,384	28,629	28,803	20,031	21,772	20,938
yoy %	1%	1%	1%		1%	1%	1%	1%
EBITA	(12,869)	(10,171)	(9,338)	687	(3,343)	(3,205)	(3,222)	(3,099)
EBITA margin %	-14.1%	-11.0%	-10.0%	2.4%	-11.6%	-16.0%	-14.8%	-14.8%
Share of profit (loss) in investees	4,956	6,733	8,354	1,013	934	1,409	1,461	1,152
Ant Financial (33% 1qr lag pick up)	6,971	7,778	8,740	1,547	1,563	1,913	1,965	1,530
Others	1,000	1,000	1,000	455	605	250	250	(105)

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

BABA	12m Price Target: \$177.00	Price: \$115.75	Upside: 52.9%
9988.HK	12m Price Target: HK\$172.00	Price: HK\$112.60	Upside: 52.8%

Buy		GS Forecast			
Market cap: \$277.8bn Enterprise value: \$274.4bn 3m ADTV: \$1.4bn China China Ecommerce & Logistics M&A Rank: 3 Leases incl. in net debt & EV?: No	Revenue (Rmb mn)	3/26	3/27E	3/28E	3/29E
	EBITDA (Rmb mn)	1,023,670.0	1,119,966.7	1,240,292.1	1,380,446.8
	EPS (Rmb)	113,483.0	166,584.3	249,068.3	323,019.0
	P/E (X)	27.36	43.17	54.71	72.65
	P/B (X)	36.5	18.0	14.2	10.7
	Dividend yield (%)	2.2	1.7	1.6	1.5
	N debt/EBITDA (ex lease,X)	1.4	2.0	2.2	2.4
	CROCI (%)	(1.1)	(0.5)	(0.1)	(0.2)
	FCF yield (%)	3.2	9.7	13.4	15.9
		(2.3)	(5.6)	(1.9)	2.4
		6/26	9/26E	12/26E	3/27E
	EPS (Rmb)	8.52	10.38	14.18	9.96

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 21 Sep 2026 close.

Disclosure Appendix

Reg AC

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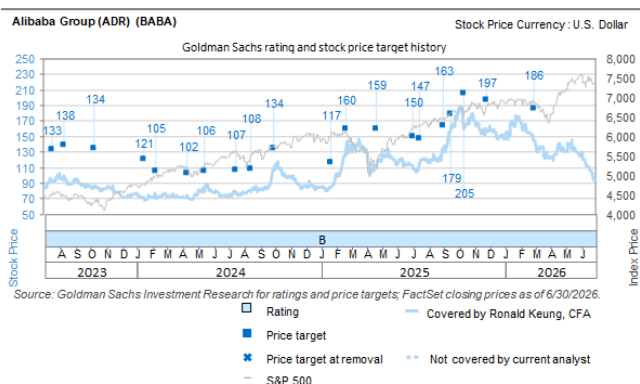
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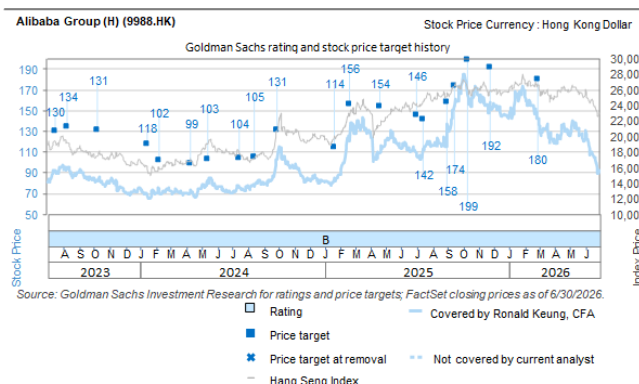
	Rating Distribution				Investment Banking Relationships		
	Buy	Hold	Sell		Buy	Hold	Sell
Global	50%	34%	16%		65%	59%	43%

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Target price history table(s)

Alibaba Group (ADR) (BABA)

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
16-Sep-26	177.00	107.27
27-Feb-26	186.00	144.11
25-Nov-25	197.00	157.01
12-Oct-25	205.00	159.01
16-Sep-25	179.00	162.21
31-Aug-25	163.00	135.00
15-Jul-25	147.00	116.97
02-Jul-25	150.00	110.71
21-Apr-25	159.00	110.15
20-Feb-25	160.00	135.97
20-Jan-25	117.00	85.12
29-Sep-24	134.00	107.33
15-Aug-24	108.00	79.54
16-Jul-24	107.00	78.38
15-May-24	106.00	80.99
11-Apr-24	102.00	74.85
07-Feb-24	105.00	73.64
15-Jan-24	121.00	71.84
09-Oct-23	134.00	84.85

Alibaba Group (H) (9988.HK)

Date of report	Target price (HK\$)	Closing price (HK\$)
16-Sep-26	172.00	106.20
27-Feb-26	180.00	142.90
25-Nov-25	192.00	157.80
12-Oct-25	199.00	165.40
16-Sep-25	174.00	153.50
31-Aug-25	158.00	115.70
15-Jul-25	142.00	113.50
02-Jul-25	146.00	109.40
21-Apr-25	154.00	108.70
20-Feb-25	156.00	120.90
20-Jan-25	114.00	84.55
29-Sep-24	131.00	102.50
15-Aug-24	105.00	76.40
16-Jul-24	104.00	75.50
15-May-24	103.00	82.65
11-Apr-24	99.00	74.20
07-Feb-24	102.00	74.90
15-Jan-24	118.00	70.00
09-Oct-23	131.00	82.10

Price targets shown in table(s) are unadjusted for corporate actions.

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